

CHAPTER 3

Trust But Verify

Your verification toolkit

Check	When to use it	How long it takes
"Did you fabricate anything?"	Every research task	5 seconds
Spot-check one specific claim	Any output with numbers or dates	30 seconds
Ask for sources	Anything going into a deliverable	1 minute
Cross-reference with a second source	High-stakes decisions or publications	5 minutes
Expert review	Anything with legal, medical, or financial consequences	Varies

The Danger Zones

Where Claude is most likely to fabricate: specific statistics and percentages, exact dates for niche events, citations and source references, names of obscure people, laws, or organizations, and details about very recent events.

The Safe Zones

Where Claude is usually reliable: general explanations of well-known concepts, widely documented historical events, common processes and how-to instructions, brainstorming and idea generation, writing and editing your own content.

The Rule to Add to Every Research Prompt

Do not fabricate information. Do not invent statistics, names, dates, or citations. If you don't have reliable information, say so.

*This reference card is a companion to Chapter 3 of Creating with Claude by Chris Thatcher.
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